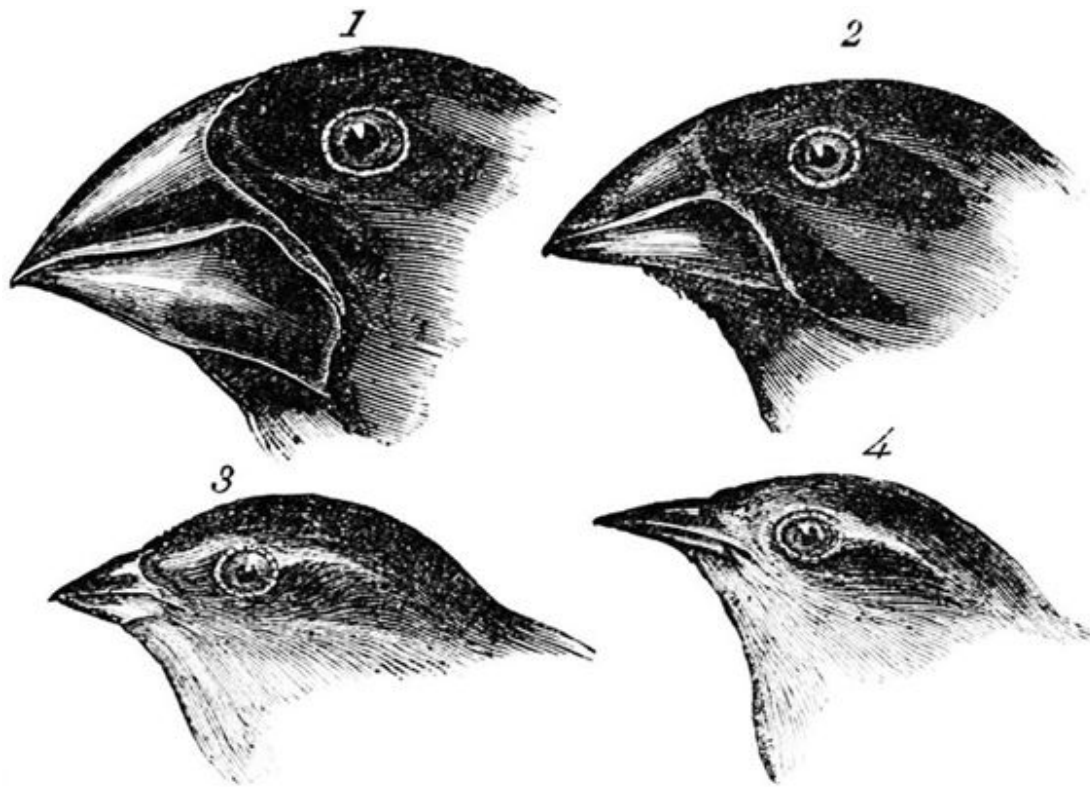


Evolution, creationism and intelligent design

Darwin's theory of natural selection further widened the gap between science and religion that had opened since the Renaissance. *On the Origin of Species* clearly contradicted the biblical account of creation and reignited the faith versus reason debate. On one side were creationists who believed in the literal truth of the Bible, on the other, the supporters of Darwin. But in the middle an argument for the existence of God from intelligent design had persisted (see [Existence of God: the teleological argument](#)), which was now effectively refuted by Darwin's theory: the diversity of life, including humans, is the result of organisms adapting to circumstances, and the apparent 'cleverness' of living things is a matter of suitability to an environment, not design.

Darwin had been raised as a Christian, but became increasingly agnostic as he developed his theory, although he continued to believe in the existence of a God. Like Isaac Newton, he believed that God created the universe and its governing laws such as natural selection, but then had no further cause to intervene.



1. *Geospiza magnirostris*.
3. *Geospiza parvula*.

2. *Geospiza fortis*.
4. *Certhidea olivacea*.

By observing features such as the various shapes of finches' beaks, Darwin concluded that the diversity of species was the result of evolution, not an immutable, divine design.